

INTERWAR AIRLINERS

THE FIRST PASSENGER TRANSPORT aircraft appeared in Europe in the aftermath of WWI. Initially they were mostly converted bombers, although Junkers and Fokker were very quick to begin production of specialized aircraft for passenger services. A wide diversity of types were flown, including both monoplanes and biplanes of either wood or metal construction. By the second half of the 1920s, safety considerations had led to a bias in favor of tri-motors – it was widely felt that if one engine failed, you would be safe with the two remaining. After the launch of the Boeing 247 in 1933, however, twin-engined all-metal aircraft dominated the airline market, at least in the United States, with the Douglas DC-3 outselling any other type. By the end of the 1930s, more powerful four-engined airliners were beginning to appear, with increased range and payload. The introduction of the pressurized cabin in the Boeing 307 Stratoliner pointed the way forward to a future of more comfortable high-altitude flight above the weather.

POPULAR DC-3

Luggage is unloaded from a United Airlines Douglas DC-3 (see pages 148–9). By the end of the 1930s, nine out of 10 air passengers in the United States were traveling on DC-2s or DC-3s.



Boeing 247

The era of the modern airliner began on February 8, 1933. With the first flight of the Boeing 247, the world's airline fleets were made to look slow, old-fashioned, and cumbersome, since it was some 70mph (113kph) faster than its competitors. However, the success of the 247 was to be its commercial undoing. With no less

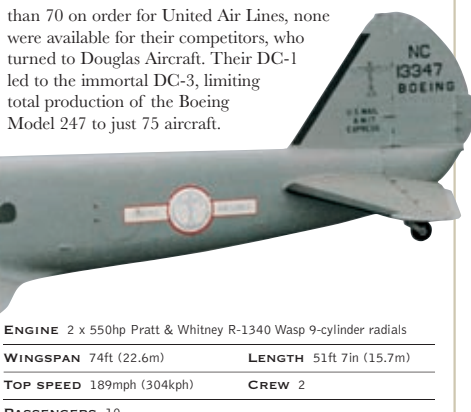
than 70 on order for United Air Lines, none were available for their competitors, who turned to Douglas Aircraft. Their DC-1 led to the immortal DC-3, limiting total production of the Boeing Model 247 to just 75 aircraft.

ENGINE 2 x 550hp Pratt & Whitney R-1340 Wasp 9-cylinder radials

WINGSPAN 74ft (22.6m) **LENGTH** 51ft 7in (15.7m)

TOP SPEED 189mph (304kph) **CREW** 2

PASSENGERS 10



Boeing 307 Stratoliner

Conceived as a commercial development of the B-17 Flying Fortress, the Stratoliner used the bomber's wings, engines, and tail, married to a new fuselage, which, unique for its time, was pressurized. For the first time passengers were carried above the bad weather that had made flying so unpleasant. Ordered by both TWA and Pan American, the first were delivered in 1940.



ENGINE 4 x 1,100hp Wright GR-1820 Cyclone 9-cylinder radial

WINGSPAN 107ft 3in (32.7m) **LENGTH** 74ft 4in (22.7m)

TOP SPEED 222mph (357kph) **CREW** 5

PASSENGERS 33

Curtiss Condor T-32 (Condor II)

While bearing the same name and superficial appearance as the Curtiss Condor 18, the T-32 was a new design that first flew in January 1933. As a biplane, the airplane was already an anachronism. Early operators included Eastern Air Transport and American Airways. An improved version, the AT-32, appeared in 1934, and most T-32s were upgraded.

ENGINE 2 x 710hp Wright Cyclone SGR-1820 9-cylinder radials

WINGSPAN 82ft (25m) **LENGTH** 48ft 7in (14.8m)

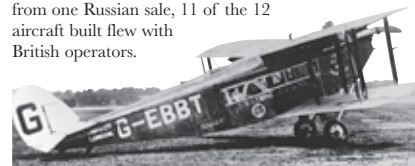
TOP SPEED 167mph (269kph) **CREW** 3

PASSENGERS 12 (sleeper version)



de Havilland D.H.34

When the first D.H.34 entered service with Daimler Airway in 1922, the passengers on the Paris route experienced new standards of comfort. Refreshments were served by a steward, and there was even a separate compartment at the rear for baggage. The crew, however, remained exposed to the elements. Apart from one Russian sale, 11 of the 12 aircraft built flew with British operators.



ENGINE 450hp Napier Lion 12-cylinder

WINGSPAN 51ft 4in (15.6m) **LENGTH** 39ft (11.9m)

TOP SPEED 105mph (169kph) **CREW** 2

PASSENGERS 9